

Embedded OSes on a PC?

Embedded operating systems have been around for quite some time, like Symbian for phones and also Linux, and are basically operating systems with all the bells and whistles removed, and are capable of carrying out only a reduced number of functions.



An embedded system

Multimedia notebooks have the

option of playing a movie without having to load up the Operating System and lug your way to the DVD play option – this is an example of an embedded OS. To understand further, consider a mobile phone. When the phone is turned on an OS boots which handles all the interface and the services of the phone, and upon this additional programs can be loaded such as JAVA applications. So an embedded system can either be made specific to an electronic device, or it can be made specific to any general purpose operating system tweaked to run on that electronic device. For a computer, an embedded OS is an additional flash memory chip which is installed on a motherboard that can be accessed through booting the PC. But now you ask – “why does a PC need a separate hardware operating system since it is more than capable of using all of its features by itself?” Well, imagine you are in a class of forty and your professor wants Viresh (replace with whatever name you prefer) to go to the Chemistry Lab to complete some experiment he missed out on. Wouldn't it look silly if the rest of the students follow him to the lab and stare at the wall while he does what he has to? Similarly, if you all want to do is waste time on Facebook do you really need to have your computer boot up and access your hard drive and rather power hungry graphics card? Continuing the train of thought, wouldn't a class of forty take more time to reach the lab – slapping each other, getting lost, or doing whatever it is kid's do in school nowadays than just Viresh going alone (think boot-time)?

So yes of course you can have an embedded OS on a PC. If you just want to watch a movie you don't have to sit through the painfully long (and it's always painfully long) boot time. More importantly, if you are a travelling businessman or a journalist and you just have to check up on something online you can do so in one step. However, don't just run